

GURNAM SINGH, *53*
Gurnam Singh Ministries, Jesus Bethel (full gospel) church, Sehnsra Kalan, Ajnala

PASTORNAMA

"I don't convert people, I only preach the Bible"

An assistant sub inspector in the Punjab Police, Singh converted to Christianity in 1998, after deciding to part ways with his family. "As my wife was unable to bear a child, my family wanted me to dump her and remarry," he says. "It was unacceptable to me. I moved to Amritsar. There, I got in touch with some pastors. With their prayers, I have three children now."
A Mazhabi Sikh, Singh sports a turban at work and preaches the Bible on his return home. He has converted his backyard into a church, where his Sunday sermon attracts 50-odd locals. "I don't convert people," he clarifies. "I only preach the Bible."

tor is willing to be, their miraculous claims run the gamut: exorcising ghosts, curing everything from cancer to joint pain to infertility, helping with everything from deaddiction to jobs, matrimonial matches and visas. Some have even claimed to bring the dead to life. Though four-year-old cancer patient Tanisha died while prayers for her were on at the Church of Glory and Wisdom, run by the colourful and controversial Haryanvi Jat Bajinder Singh at Jalandhar's Tajpur village, faith in healing runs unabated. "People question its veracity, but miracles are possible, and crucial for the faith," says Deol. Miracle is the stuff of all religion, of course. Sufi dargahs, Vedic yagnas, the Dukh Bhanjani Beri tree on the parikrama around Harmandir Sahib...all rest on the idea of miracle sprung via supernatural intercession, and it's tricky to argue that modern devotees do not *really* believe in it. What, then, distinguishes the Charismatic faithful? The Pentecostal movement in Punjab, like the dera heads, believes that faith must be powerfully experiential and not merely ritual, with emphasis on the believers' direct ex-